

Catan Base Game Rules

Seed Fixture - Synthetic Reference Document (5th Edition)

This document is a synthetic seed fixture for the Tabletop Oracle project. It contains original text summarising game mechanics for use in automated testing of the document ingestion pipeline, knowledge graph construction, and AI query validation. This is not a copy of any copyrighted rulebook.

Overview

Catan is a multiplayer board game for 3 to 4 players designed by Klaus Teuber and first published in 1995 by Kosmos. Players take on the role of settlers establishing colonies on the island of Catan. The game combines resource management, trading, and strategic building. The objective is to be the first player to reach 10 victory points through a combination of settlements, cities, development cards, and special achievements.

Components

The game includes 19 terrain hexes (4 forest, 4 pasture, 4 fields, 3 hills, 3 mountains, 1 desert), 6 sea frame pieces, 18 circular number tokens (numbered 2 through 12, excluding 7), 95 resource cards (19 each of lumber, wool, grain, brick, and ore), 25 development cards (14 knight cards, 5 victory point cards, 2 road building cards, 2 year of plenty cards, 2 monopoly cards), 4 building costs reference cards, 2 special cards (Longest Road and Largest Army), 16 cities (4 per colour), 20 settlements (5 per colour), 60 roads (15 per colour), 1 robber pawn, and 2 dice.

Setup

Arrange the 19 terrain hexes randomly within the sea frame to form the island. Place number tokens on each terrain hex (except the desert) in alphabetical order following the spiral pattern shown in the almanac. The desert hex receives the robber pawn. Each player selects a colour and takes 5 settlements, 4 cities, and 15 roads of that colour. Players take turns placing 1 settlement at any intersection of three hexes and 1 road adjacent to it. After all players have placed their first settlement and road, placement continues in reverse order for the second settlement and road. Each player collects 1 resource card for each terrain hex adjacent to their second settlement.

Terrain and Resources

Each terrain hex produces a specific resource when its number is rolled. Forest hexes produce lumber. Pasture hexes produce wool. Fields produce grain. Hills produce brick. Mountains produce ore. The desert hex produces no resources. Resource cards are the currency of the game -- they are spent to build roads, settlements, cities, and to buy development cards.

Turn Structure

On each turn, a player performs three phases in order. First, the player rolls both dice and sums the result. Every player who has a settlement adjacent to a terrain hex matching the rolled number receives 1 resource card of that type. Players with a city adjacent to the hex receive 2 resource cards instead. Second, the player may trade resources with other players or with the bank (see Trading). Third, the player may build roads, settlements, or cities, or buy development cards by paying the required resources (see Building).

Trading

There are two forms of trading: domestic trade and maritime trade. In domestic trade, the active player may offer resources to any other player and negotiate freely. Only the active player may initiate trades. Other players may not trade among themselves. In maritime trade, any player may trade 4 identical resource cards of any type to the bank for 1 resource card of any other type. If a player has a settlement or city on a harbour, they may trade at a better rate. Generic harbours allow 3:1 trades of any resource. Specific harbours (e.g., lumber harbour) allow 2:1 trades of the named resource.

Building

Players build by paying resource cards to the bank. A road costs 1 brick and 1 lumber. A settlement costs 1 brick, 1 lumber, 1 wool, and 1 grain. A city upgrade (replacing a settlement) costs 2 grain and 3 ore. A development card costs 1 wool, 1 grain, and 1 ore. Roads are placed along the edges between hexes and must connect to an existing road, settlement, or city belonging to the player. Settlements are placed at intersections where three hexes meet and must be connected to the player's road network. The distance rule requires that no two settlements (or cities) may be placed on adjacent intersections -- there must be at least 2 edges between any two settlements. Cities replace existing settlements and produce double resources.

Development Cards

Development cards are purchased for 1 wool, 1 grain, and 1 ore and drawn from the shuffled development card deck. A player may play at most 1 development card per turn, and may not play a card on the same turn it was purchased. Knight cards: when played, the player moves the robber to any terrain hex and steals 1 random resource card from a player with a settlement or city adjacent to that hex. Road Building: the player immediately places 2 roads at no cost. Year of Plenty: the player takes any 2 resource cards from the bank. Monopoly: the player names 1 resource type and all other players must give all their cards of that type to the player. Victory Point cards are kept hidden and revealed only when the player reaches 10 victory points.

The Robber

When a player rolls a 7, no resources are produced. Instead, every player with more than 7 resource cards must discard half (rounded down). The player who rolled the 7 must then move the robber pawn to any terrain hex other than its current location. While the robber is on a hex, that hex does not produce resources when its number is rolled. After moving the robber, the player may steal 1 random resource card from any player who has a settlement or city adjacent to the robber's new hex.

Special Cards

Longest Road: the first player to build a continuous road of at least 5 segments receives the Longest Road card, worth 2 victory points. If another player builds a longer continuous road, the card transfers to that player. **Largest Army:** the first player to play 3 knight development cards receives the Largest Army card, worth 2 victory points. If another player plays more knights, the card transfers to that player.

Victory Conditions

The game ends immediately when a player reaches 10 or more victory points on their turn. Victory points are earned as follows: each settlement is worth 1 victory point, each city is worth 2 victory points, the Longest Road card is worth 2 victory points, the Largest Army card is worth 2 victory points, and each victory point development card is worth 1 victory point. A player may only win during their own turn. If a player reaches 10 points during another player's turn (e.g., due to Longest Road transfer), they do not win until their own next turn, when they must announce their victory.